

Heracles's second task was even more difficult than the first. He was sent to kill the Lernaean hydra—a terrifying monster with nine snakelike heads and a scaly body.

*The hydra lived in the swamps surrounding Lerna, where it devoured the cattle of the local farmers.*

Heracles invited his nephew Iolaos to join him on this task, and together they rode to the hydra's marshy lair. They crept up behind the monster and Heracles swished his sword, chopping off one of the hydra's heads. However, no sooner had the head fallen to the ground, than two more heads grew back in its place. Heracles tried again, but the same thing happened.

Iolaos had an idea. He started a fire while Heracles battled the enraged hydra and heated his sword until it glowed red-hot. Iolaos then followed Heracles, burning the stump of each head as soon as Heracles had lopped it off, which stopped any more from growing back. Together, the two men worked to defeat the hydra and complete the second task.

